

Chapter 39-1

The autumn in Haishuo City is often rainy.

After nightfall, dark clouds pressed down like a besieging army, and a gentle autumn rain quietly arrived.

Xu Qingzhu was awakened by the sound of rain. After waking up, she turned on the warm yellow bedside lamp. She was wearing a water-blue silk nightgown, with her long hair loosely falling by her waist.

The rain gradually grew heavier, and raindrops blew in along with the wind, falling onto the dark-colored curtains.

Xu Qingzhu got up to close the window.

Raindrops gathered on the glass, gradually extending into fine dense lines of rain, meandering downward.

She was completely without sleepiness now.

Glancing at her watch, the hour hand had just slid past "1."

Recently, with too many things piling up and high psychological pressure, Xu Qingzhu often woke up in the middle of the night.

However, after waking up tonight, instead of starting to handle work as usual, she turned on her computer and began researching.

She looked up astrophysics, cosmic civilizations—basically researching all kinds of strange and peculiar things.

After researching for a while, she snapped the computer shut with a "pa."

...

She must be going crazy.

Xu Qingzhu tapped her own head, "Believe in science."

—Extraterrestrials also count as part of science.

So she began researching again, drawing out increasingly complex things—black holes, wormholes, time-space travel.

There were no shortage of fraudsters fishing in troubled waters.

Xu Qingzhu couldn't research anything conclusive, so she searched [Why does a person suddenly become different from before?]

The answers below were also varied and diverse.

[Maybe they grew up. People grow up in just an instant.]

[Car accident amnesia?]

[Split personality?]

[Changes in environment cause changes in thinking, and changes in thinking bring about behavioral changes.]

[...]

Xu Qingzhu closed the computer again.

There were many answers, but not one was useful.

She really was crazy, to be looking for answers on the internet.

Maybe she was stimulated by tonight's events.

At that time, she was so close to getting Liang Shi to reveal something.

Liang Shi's panic couldn't be faked.

Xu Qingzhu closed her eyes and let out a light sigh.

Forget it, there would be plenty of time ahead.

She didn't need to be too interested in these things, but everything related to Liang Shi appeared in her life every day.

Every day she discovered new skills of Liang Shi's.

This person was like a huge whirlpool, constantly attracting her to come closer.

If she wasn't careful, she would be drawn into the whirlpool.

Xu Qingzhu put the computer aside and forced herself to change her train of thought.

Chapter 39-2

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Similarly, Liang Shi also hadn't slept well all night.

Because of Xu Qingzhu's sudden flirtation, she had dreamed all night.

Although she knew it was a test, her touch was real, her breath was real.

In that instant, she had even smelled the strawberry Baileys scent on Xu Qingzhu's body.

Carrying a slightly intoxicated drunkenness, faint and elusive.

In her dreams, desire and darkness intertwined.

When she woke up early in the morning, she changed into fresh underwear.

The next morning, the two ate breakfast in wordless silence.

The atmosphere revealed an eerie calm.

It was still Xu Qingzhu who broke the silence first, asking calmly: "When are you going to audition?"

"This afternoon." Liang Shi finished the warm water in her hand, turned around to get another cup of water to wash the cup, "I've already asked for leave from my supervisor."

"Then I wish you success." Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi placed the washed cup aside, smiled slightly, and finally found the feeling of her usual interactions with her, "I also wish your new product launch goes smoothly."

"It definitely will." Xu Qingzhu said with certainty.

Today she wore a black high-neck tight-fitting base shirt, paired with black high-waisted wide-leg pants. Her hair was pinned up, making her face appear even more delicate and small. When she smiled, even her eyes sparkled, displaying a confident and radiant smile.

Liang Shi suddenly stared in a daze.

This was the first time she had seen such a confident Xu Qingzhu, as if the whole world was beneath her feet and she could effortlessly obtain everything.

After Liang Shi realized her inappropriate behavior, she turned her face away and cleared her throat softly.

To cover up, Liang Shi pretended to tease by raising an eyebrow and asking: "So certain?"

"Yes." Xu Qingzhu said: "My judgment in this area has never been wrong."

Liang Shi slowly nodded, originally thinking what she said made sense, but Xu Qingzhu asked: "You don't believe me?"

"How could that be?" Liang Shi immediately said: "How could I not believe Teacher Xu?"

Xu Qingzhu: "...?"

The same teacher title was kicked back to her like a ball, which truly stunned Xu Qingzhu for a moment.

Xu Qingzhu laughed hoarsely, but didn't take the loss lying down, "Then I'll trust Teacher Liang's words first."

Liang Shi: "..."

This small episode quickly passed.

But Liang Shi felt that this "passive-aggressive" behavior regarding titles between them might continue for a long time.

Before leaving, Liang Shi suddenly remembered, "Is your new product launch going to be livestreamed?"

"Mm." Xu Qingzhu said: "At two in the afternoon."

Liang Shi: "..."

Her expression cracked.

"What's wrong?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

"Nothing." Liang Shi looked troubled, "My audition is also at two in the afternoon. I was originally planning to watch your livestream."

Xu Qingzhu smiled slightly, "Teacher Liang is so thoughtful."

Liang Shi: "...?"

Before she could confirm whether Xu Qingzhu was being passive-aggressive, Xu Qingzhu timely added, "Sincerely."

Liang Shi was helpless, "Alright. But I'll try my best to make time to watch. You have to work hard."

Xu Qingzhu's lips curved upward, radiant and unrestrained, "Teacher Liang, have some confidence in me."

"Okay." Liang Shi was infected by her emotions, "Teacher Xu is the best."

"Then..." Xu Qingzhu put on her high heels, wearing a well-tailored suit jacket over her outfit, as if putting on armor, yet said with a smile: "I wish Teacher Liang success in getting the role and an early entry into the entertainment industry."

Liang Shi: "...Okay."

"By the way." Liang Shi suddenly said: "This drama will probably involve competing with Chen Liuying¹. Would you mind?"

Xu Qingzhu paused, asking nonchalantly: "Why would I mind?"

"Last time because of my situation, you and your friend..." Liang Shi didn't finish the rest of her words, but her expression was sheepish: "So I'm worried that you might have unpleasantness again because of this matter."

"If I said I minded, would you not go?" Xu Qingzhu still asked in return.

Liang Shi thought for two seconds and answered firmly: "No."

Xu Qingzhu smiled, her tone casual, "Then it seems I'm not that important to Teacher Liang."

"It's not that." Liang Shi pressed her lips together, "This has nothing to do with whether you're important or not. In this industry, roles cannot be yielded."

Xu Qingzhu glanced at her watch. Time was running short, so she stopped teasing Liang Shi and said very seriously: "I understand, so go ahead and do it boldly. Everyone competes fairly. If you back down because of me, then I would become your burden instead. Liang Shi, no matter when, I hope you can prioritize your own situation, especially at work."

"But your feelings are also very important." Liang Shi subconsciously replied.

Xu Qingzhu's hand on the car door paused, and she leisurely and languidly stretched out her tone, "Hmm?"

"Never mind, never mind." Liang Shi panicked and immediately urged her to go to work, "It's nothing. You should go quickly, you'll be late."

Saying this, she also hurriedly got in her car.

Xu Qingzhu looked back at her once, but she didn't look over again.

Footnotes: ¹ Chen Liuying: A rival actress character who has been mentioned in previous chapters as competing for the same roles as Liang Shi

Chapter 39-3

When she arrived at the company, as Xu Qingzhu was waiting for the elevator downstairs, her phone vibrated slightly.

Liang Shi sent a message—

【Acting is something I quite like, so I can't yield. But if you really want me to avoid Chen Liuying, I would also avoid her. I don't want my presence to cause your interpersonal relationships to become worse, it's just that I would be unhappy that way. So I'm very happy that you're letting me boldly pursue this.】

A few seconds later, there was another message—

【Teacher Xu, I forgot to say, you look super beautiful today! Fearless you will definitely be invincible! Go for it! I will definitely get the role to celebrate for you!】

Xu Qingzhu stared at the screen, confirming again and again that it was indeed sent by Liang Shi.

Looking at it, she was actually infected by the emotions in those words and couldn't help but laugh.

"Blanche, what's making you so happy so early in the morning?" Sally walked over carrying a cup of iced americano, and naturally leaned her head over to look at her screen. Xu Qingzhu immediately turned off the screen and restrained her smile, "Nothing."

"Oh?" Sally obviously didn't believe it, "Your mouth is almost stretching to the back of your ears."

Xu Qingzhu rolled her eyes at her, "What nonsense? How ugly would that make me look?"

Sally described it dramatically: "You know the big-mouthed monkey¹? Just like that."

Lin Luoxi couldn't stand it anymore and interrupted: "That's enough, you're really ugly right now."

Sally: "...Blanche was just like that, and you still said she was cute."

Lin Luoxi: "Making funny faces requires good looks. Unfortunately, you don't have that."

Sally looked hurt, "OMG, Cherry, you used to say I was the most beautiful person in this world."

Lin Luoxi with a cold face: "Don't talk to me in such a disgusting tone. Also, I used to be nearsighted at fifteen hundred degrees."

Sally: "What?"

Lin Luoxi with a death smile: "I was basically blind."

Sally: "..."

Xu Qingzhu witnessed a verbal sparring match in the elevator, and Sally was defeated as usual.

When getting out of the elevator, Xu Qingzhu consolatorily but also somewhat gloatingly patted Sally's shoulder.

Sally: "..."

She felt like she had suffered a double critical hit.

"Come to a meeting in ten minutes." Xu Qingzhu said to these two: "Also, call Zhou Yi'an."

"Okay." Lin Luoxi agreed.

After returning to the office, Xu Qingzhu reopened her phone and found that Liang Shi had sent her two more messages.

【By the way, I didn't buy that trending topic last time. I don't have money to buy trending topics.】

【If your friend calls again, just say it was something I insisted on doing and you didn't know. Tell her to call me directly.】

Xu Qingzhu couldn't help but find it amusing, yet she lowered her head to tap the screen and replied: 【Where's your money?】

Liang Shi replied instantly: 【Didn't I give it all to you?】

— 【Did you think fifty thousand yuan could buy a trending topic?】

— 【Wouldn't Chen Liuying have to live on trending topics every day then?】

Xu Qingzhu: 【...】

After five seconds of silence, Xu Qingzhu transferred one hundred thousand yuan to her.

Liang Shi clicked to return it.

Liang Shi: 【I didn't mean to ask for money.】

— 【If you give it to me like this, wouldn't that make me look like an internet beggar?】

— 【If you really want to give it, I prefer cash (just kidding)】

Xu Qingzhu: 【...Not a cent left.】

Xu Qingzhu suddenly noticed: 【You seem to be talking unusually much today.】

Liang Shi: 【Sweating.jpg】

After a while, Liang Shi sent: 【Can I say that I'm a bit nervous?】

Xu Qingzhu: 【...You can.】

Liang Shi: 【What if I don't act well? What if Chen Liuying takes this role? I'll be looked down upon.】

Xu Qingzhu stared intently at the screen, thinking about how to respond appropriately.

How could she both encourage Liang Shi without hurting her self-esteem, while also making her face reality?

No matter how bad Chen Liuying was, she had still acted in two dramas. How could someone who had just barely stepped into the entertainment industry with her toes compare?

That trending topic last time—anyone with eyes could see it was bought by Chen Liuying's competitors to step on Chen Liuying, and had nothing to do with whether Liang Shi's acting was good or not.

She typed several sentences, all of which she deleted before sending.

Deleting and reducing, she surprisingly couldn't think of a single appropriate thing to say.

She kept procrastinating until Sally and Cherry came in holding their computers.

Zhou Yi'an was last, swaggering with one hand in her pocket, looking like a cool sister, but she still closed the door when she came in.

Xu Qingzhu sighed helplessly and quickly tapped the screen with her fingers: 【Impossible. Chen Liuying's acting is terrible. This role is definitely yours.】

— 【Your acting is so much better than hers. If you're not chosen, it must be underhanded dealings—the director has poor judgment.】

The moment those two messages were sent, Xu Qingzhu suddenly felt like she was a master at making empty promises.

But most importantly, she felt that the truth wasn't so important anymore.

At times like this, it was better to be blindly protective.

After all... she was one of her own people.

Footnotes: ¹ Big-mouthed monkey: Refers to a cartoon character or emoji with an exaggeratedly wide smile, used here as a humorous comparison

Chapter 39-4

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After seeing those two messages, Liang Shi was full of energy all morning.

Although she briefly suspected whether Xu Qingzhu's account had been hacked.

Nothing gave one more courage than someone firmly believing in you.

So Liang Shi chose to—believe her.

She quickly finished her morning work. When handing in her weekly report to Zhou Li, even Zhou Li couldn't help but ask her, "Are you this happy just about going to audition?"

"What what? Audition?" Li Ran appeared from nowhere, "Little Liang, you're going to audition?"

"Mm." Liang Shi said: "Sister Ying¹ said there's a role that suits me quite well and asked me to try for it."

"Wow~!" Li Ran's eyes lit up, "Is this the power of capital? Following Zhao Ying, Little Liang, you'll definitely be a smooth-sailing big star in the future!"

Liang Shi: "..."

She suddenly felt a bit overwhelmed.

This pie² was slightly too big.

"You'll have to sign a hundred autographs for me later." Li Ran fantasized about a beautiful future, "I'll hang them on the Xianyu app³ and make a fortune directly."

Liang Shi: "Illegal profit-making, Sister Ran. Your idea is really criminal."

Li Ran: "..."

Li Ran glanced at her, "How are you talking? I'm just exploiting a loophole."

"Yes." Liang Shi said seriously while joking, "Exploiting legal loopholes. These days are getting more and more promising⁴."

Li Ran: "..."

She pressed her temples, "Little Liang, you really know how to talk."

Liang Shi: "Just okay, not as good as Sister Ran at getting things done."

Li Ran: "..."

Unable to bear it anymore, Li Ran slapped her shoulder, "Really too much, making fun of me."

Liang Shi smiled warmly. Zhou Li looked helplessly at the two of them, mainly at Li Ran, "You really know how to make money."

Li Ran shrugged, "I was just joking. But Little Liang, if your audition is successful, will you still come to work?"

"I don't know." Liang Shi said: "Even if they decide on the actors, filming will still take some time. I'll definitely be here during this period."

Li Ran suddenly became sentimental, "Although you haven't been here long, we've already gotten used to having you here."

"Mainly enjoying the benefits that Little Liang brings when she's here." Zhou Li mercilessly exposed the truth, "Alright, go work. Don't keep talking about this. Keep it confidential."

Li Ran zipped her mouth, "I understand."

When she was about to leave, she still patted Liang Shi's shoulder, "Little Liang, work hard. The talent stream⁵ is always invincible."

Liang Shi: "...Okay."

She had just worked hard when others didn't know about it.

It wasn't particularly strong talent stream either.

Although in her previous world, her entry into the entertainment industry had been smoother than most people's.

Zhou Li checked her weekly report and said there were no problems.

As Liang Shi was turning to leave, Zhou Li suddenly said in a serious voice: "Liang Shi."

Liang Shi turned back: "Ah?"

"Seize the opportunity well." Zhou Li said: "I wish you success in your audition."

Liang Shi was flattered and immediately smiled: "Okay, thank you Sister Li."

"This is something Rainbow asked me to give you." Zhou Li said, taking a round keychain from the desk, "She made this herself and asked me to wish you success on her behalf."

"Okay."

Liang Shi took it and found that the pattern on the keychain was a Q-version⁶ of herself, with a line of small text below: Big Star.

...

The kindness of children always made people feel warm.

Footnotes: ¹ Sister Ying: Refers to Zhao Ying, Liang Shi's contact in the entertainment industry who has been helping her get audition opportunities ² Pie: Chinese slang meaning "unrealistic promises" or "empty promises," literally "drawing a pie" (画饼) ³ Xianyu app: A popular Chinese second-hand trading platform owned by Alibaba ⁴ Promising (有判头): A humorous play on words, as "判" (pan) sounds like "盼" (pan, meaning hope/promise), but "判" means "judge/sentence," creating a pun about legal judgment ⁵ Talent stream: Internet slang referring to people who succeed primarily due to natural talent rather than hard work ⁶ Q-version: A cute, chibi-style cartoon representation of a character with exaggerated features

Chapter 39-5

At noon, Liang Shi was also called to the office by Liang Xinhe and learned about her upcoming audition. He expressed shock, but after the shock, he regained his rationality and said coldly: "Go ahead then."

Liang Shi: "...?"

"Second brother, do you think I can't do it?" Liang Shi asked in return.

Liang Xinhe's tone was perfunctory: "You can do it. There's nothing in this world that my little sister can't do."

Liang Shi: "...Then I'll prove it to you."

Liang Xinhe: "Okay."

However, Liang Xinhe originally didn't think Liang Shi could stay in the workplace for too long. It was obvious that she didn't like staying in the company.

As long as she didn't mess around like before, running to casinos all the time, or drinking and partying wildly with a bunch of friends, anywhere was fine.

Acting in the entertainment industry was also quite good. The Liang family could afford to support this idle person.

Liang Xinhe called her mainly to ask, "Regarding the vacancy for the magazine department head, who do you think would be suitable to fill the position?"

Liang Shi was puzzled: "You're asking me?"

"Yes, asking you." Liang Xinhe suddenly paused, "You haven't just been freeloading in the magazine department this whole time, have you?"

This comment was like stepping on her tail. Liang Shi immediately jumped up, "How is that possible?"

"Second brother, you can't wrongly accuse me." Liang Shi said: "My recent performance has been obvious to all. Our team leader is very satisfied."

"So I'm asking you, who do you think is suitable?" Liang Xinhe said.

"What do you think?" Liang Shi asked in return: "You can't possibly not have someone in mind."

No matter what, the magazine department was also one of Dongheng Group's main forces going forward.

Such important personnel appointments wouldn't listen to her hasty decisions.

"I'm asking you now." Liang Xinhe curved his fingers and tapped the table, "You're only responsible for answering."

Liang Shi: "..."

"Our team leader then." Liang Shi said: "It's not because she's our team leader that I'm being biased toward her. It's her ability and vision that I think are very suitable. As for the others, the one from the GG group has too active a mind—maybe it's related to her position. She always likes to be opportunistic and two-faced. The one from the wardrobe group is a bit too pretentious, crying for a long time even over a small scrape..."

She listed them all around and still came to this conclusion in the end.

And Liang Xinhe only coldly indicated, "Got it."

Liang Shi went up inexplicably and came downstairs inexplicably.

However, on the way to drive to her audition, she received a transfer notification from Liang Xinhe.

Liang Xinhe transferred two hundred thousand yuan to her.

[Buy some clothes, get a new assistant. Don't be so shabby—it's embarrassing.]

Liang Shi: "..."

However, she suddenly remembered something and sent Liang Xinhe a voice message: "Second brother, what does our family want that land in the south of the city for? Even if it gets approved, what's the use?"

A company that makes luxury goods—what would they want land for? They're not in real estate.

Liang Xinhe asked in return: 【Did you contact Zhou Yi'an?】

Liang Shi patiently said: "Even if we really need this land, we should fight for it openly. Why do I need to contact Zhou Yi'an?"

She then pretended to be angry and sent: "I'm not a courtesan¹."

Liang Xinhe: 【...Who said you were a courtesan?】

Liang Xinhe: 【Mom said you and Zhou Yi'an were classmates and had a good relationship, so you could help make connections. Even without you, we can still get it.】

Liang Xinhe: 【Last time because of you, we even offended Zhou Yi'an? What land are we still fighting for? We're not fighting for it anymore.】

Liang Shi looked at his indifferent tone and suddenly had an idea, continuing to say: "Then wouldn't the family company go bankrupt?"

Liang Xinhe sent a voice message with some helpless laughter, seeming to mock her stupidity.

"Liang Shi, are you crazy? I have such a big Dongheng Group—would it go bankrupt because we can't get one piece of land? Our family originally makes luxury goods. Getting that land was just to develop in other directions. Even if the market is being squeezed now, our family hasn't fallen to the point of bankruptcy."

Liang Shi: "..."

Her heart suddenly felt heavy.

"Getting that land would be icing on the cake. Not getting it wouldn't hurt either." Liang Xinhe said, then suddenly paused for a few seconds and said in a strange tone: "This wouldn't be the reason you've been so well-behaved recently, would it? Even dressing so shabbily—what, are you saving money for the family?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Well, not really.

Liang Xinhe transferred another two hundred thousand yuan to her.

[Don't be so shabby anymore. The family doesn't lack these few coins from you.]

Liang Shi: "..."

She explained: "I already said it's for work requirements. What would a small employee like me dress so well for?"

"Everyone in the company now knows you're Third Miss Liang. What small employee?" Liang Xinhe: "Only you still believe that."

Liang Shi: "..."

Helplessly covering her face.jpg

However, Liang Shi also clarified one thing through this.

Although the Liang family was gradually declining, it was far from being on the verge of bankruptcy as Qiu Zimin had described.

Moreover, Liang Xinhe and the others had no idea about Qiu Zimin wanting the original owner to divorce and be with Zhou Yi'an.

So all of this was very likely planned by Qiu Zimin alone?

She was deceiving both sides—telling Liang Shi on one side that it was for the family's good, while telling Liang Xinhe and the others that Liang Shi was voluntarily contributing.

This created an information gap.

For the original owner, Qiu Zimin would always use such rhetoric that would make her help unconditionally.

Even if she was unwilling, she would never go against Qiu Zimin's wishes.

On the way to Qingcheng Theater, Liang Shi had a brainstorm in her mind, trying her best to sort out the character relationships in this matter.

Something seemed about to emerge.

Until she arrived at Qingcheng Theater, she still hadn't figured it out.

The information she had was limited, so she couldn't completely deduce the result.

But from what she had deduced, Qiu Zimin definitely hated the original owner to the bone.

Otherwise, there was no reason to explain her behavior.

Footnotes: ¹ Courtesan (媛交): A derogatory internet slang term combining "媛" (yuan, meaning a beautiful woman) and "交" (jiao, meaning social interaction/交际), implying someone who uses their looks or charm for social/business advantages

Chapter 39-6

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About to audition, Liang Shi also quickly got into character and put all these matters behind her.

There were many people coming to audition. Nearly a hundred people were standing in the fourth-floor corridor, all dressed up beautifully. Looking around, Liang Shi seemed like an oddball.

She was still wearing the same professional suit she had worn to work in the morning, which didn't match the character she was auditioning for at all.

Some people had even made their own costumes at their own expense, looking as if they were already on a film set.

Liang Shi arrived late, and by the time she got there, there were no more spots. A staff member recorded her name and gave her a number tag: A376.

She thought she was ranked in the three hundreds, but after asking the staff, she learned it was the 76th person auditioning for the third female lead.

There were also people here auditioning for other roles.

After getting her number tag, Liang Shi sent a message to Zhao Ying: 【Sister Ying, I'm here!】

Zhao Ying: 【OK, good luck.】

There was no other exchange after that.

During the time waiting in the corridor, Liang Shi spent it all familiarizing herself with the script lines.

Although you could look at the script while reading lines during auditions, this obviously wasn't something an actor who wanted to get the role would do.

Liang Shi continued familiarizing herself with the lines.

After an unknown amount of time, she suddenly heard someone nearby say: "Hey, come watch together."

"Watch what?" another person asked.

"Today is Minghui Jewelry's new product launch. I heard that Minghui's eldest daughter will personally host it."

"Really? Didn't they say she married into a wealthy family? Why would she still come out to work publicly?"

"..."

They discussed in low voices excitedly, when a cool voice cut in: "If she doesn't come out, the Sheng family's little bit of industry will be gone."

The former jewelry empire was now also severely declining.

Liang Shi looked toward the person speaking—dressed in simple casual wear, sweatpants and a sports jacket, with a gray baseball cap and round large earrings. The outfit didn't match, but because of her face, it showed a strange kind of beauty.

The people who had just been discussing paused, turned to look over, and suddenly covered their mouths in shock, even tugging at their neighbor's arm.

Her companion was still playing on her phone and was startled by the tugging, saying without looking up: "What?"

"Holy sht *sht* sh*t." That person was shocked to the point of pupil earthquake¹, "It's it's it..."

"Who is it?" Her companion also looked up, then had the same pupil earthquake.

Liang Shi: "...?"

Was it that exaggerated?

"Shh." The woman took out a white mask from her pocket and put it on, "Just pretend you didn't see me. Continue what you were doing."

Everyone: "..."

Obviously very excited inside, but having to desperately suppress their emotions, frantically nodding.

Then that woman swaggered through the corridor, passing through the crowded crowd. Everyone was busy looking at scripts and playing on their phones, so no one paid attention to her anymore.

However, she entered the audition room.

Liang Shi didn't understand what was happening, but she stole some time to take out her phone and found the livestream of Minghui Jewelry's autumn new product launch online.

Footnotes: ¹ Pupil earthquake (瞳孔地震): Chinese internet slang meaning extreme shock or surprise, describing when someone's pupils dilate from shock, as if experiencing an "earthquake"

Chapter 39-7

The livestream hadn't started yet. Various media outlets were still adjusting their equipment. From the videos that had already been revealed, the venue seemed quite grand and beautiful, better than in previous years.

Liang Shi switched out of the stream and sent Xu Qingzhu an emoji: 【Go for it.jpg】

Xu Qingzhu replied instantly: 【Received.jpg】

Then Xu Qingzhu sent: 【Teacher Liang, charge ahead!】

Liang Shi: 【...Okay.】

Meanwhile, the girls nearby began frantically discussing the person who had just passed by.

"Damn, my goddess is really so cool."

"Just standing there, I want to say, sleep with me!"

"Damn, it's broad daylight. Can you be a bit more reserved? But I also want to say, sister, sleep with me."

"Are you all crazy? There should be limits to idol worship. I heard she's having an ambiguous relationship with Zhao Ying."

Everyone fell silent in unison.

A few seconds later, they collectively attacked the person who spoke: "Are you crazy? Who doesn't know that Yang Shuyan's¹ fans and Zhao Ying's fans tear each other apart every day? Could those two be together?"

"The fans have already torn each other into a bloody sea. The celebrities themselves couldn't possibly step on their fans' corpses to date, right? That way they'd definitely lose countless fans."

"I don't believe it. Even if the sky falls and the earth collapses, Yang Shuyan could never be with Zhao Ying."

"If Yang Shuyan and Zhao Ying got together, then I think I could marry this beautiful woman too."

While speaking, she pointed at a girl's phone screen next to her, so everyone looked over in unison and saw a woman in a white suit and black tight-fitting base shirt on the screen. She had light makeup on, and just a gentle smile could tug at people's heartstrings.

The perfect combination of brightness and purity in her—she stood there as if she were a glowing entity.

No one wouldn't like her.

In an instant, everyone collectively gasped.

"Damn, I can do this. What kind of stunning beauty is this?"

"The kind that makes your heart race just by looking."

"I suddenly feel like my Sister Shuyan isn't as appealing anymore."

"Let me handle this. I've got my ID and household registration ready. I just need this beauty's contact information."

"..."

Everyone looked at her like she was crazy, and she silently lowered her head, then asked back with righteous indignation: "Don't you all want to?"

Everyone: "..."

Well, they did want to.

"She's married, okay?" Fortunately, someone remained rational, "Miss Xu from the Xu family. She was on trending topics once before, but it was quickly taken down. I heard she married the third miss of Dongheng Group."

"Today is another heartbreaking day." The person who had just been clamoring about having her ID and household registration ready now wilted, "Why are all the beautiful sisters taken by others?"

"But I heard she and Third Miss Liang don't get along after marriage and are about to divorce. You still have a chance."

That person's eyes suddenly brightened!

Liang Shi, who was watching Xu Qingzhu confidently facing the media and giving speeches on screen: "..."

Although... but...

Who said anything about divorce?

Liang Shi was dazed by this sudden gossip bombshell.

She even wanted to hide the Xu Qingzhu on screen.

"But it's true. If their relationship were harmonious, she wouldn't come out to work publicly. Wouldn't being the young mistress of Dongheng Group be better?" They began discussing again.

"Didn't my goddess just say? If she doesn't come out, Minghui will go bankrupt."

"But what use is her coming out? Could she really change the current situation single-handedly?"

"To be honest, my mom used to frequently buy Minghui products, but in recent years she's switched to Haiwei². No choice—Minghui's products have gotten uglier and uglier these past few years."

"Yeah, many celebrities don't use them anymore."

"..."

Liang Shi silently listened to their gossip, feeling mixed emotions inside. Looking at Xu Qingzhu on screen, she somehow detected a sense of "a hero's twilight, yet ambition undimmed" desolation.

She opened the livestream's comment section. Most comments said that Minghui Jewelry's new products this year definitely wouldn't work, and only this eldest daughter was worth watching, but after keeping people in suspense for so long, they had already worn out people's patience.

She never usually commented when watching livestreams or dramas, thinking it unnecessary.

But today, a sense of mission suddenly descended from heaven.

[Teacher Xu is so beautiful! Too gorgeous! Confident women are the best!]

[This year's Minghui will definitely bring us surprises!]

[Teacher Xu's outfit today is so beautiful. Such stylish clothes—I love them so much.]

[Jewelry chosen by someone with such good aesthetic sense will definitely be dazzling.]

[...]

She posted more than twenty comments in a row, almost all different.

In the past, when she was bored and couldn't sleep, she would open her Weibo comment section or her fan club to look at content posted by fans. She had seen those rainbow farts³, and although she hadn't completely memorized them, she remembered about seventy to eighty percent.

Now she used them all here.

Meanwhile, at the backstage of Minghui Jewelry's official livestream.

Sally looked at this account that kept posting comments and felt it looked familiar. She had a staff member click into the account's profile, and the account bio clearly read: Liang Shi.

Not even trying to hide it.

Sally was like she had discovered a new continent and immediately called Lin Luoxi over to look.

Lin Luoxi had originally found her annoying, but after seeing so many rainbow fart comments, she was both amused and exasperated.

For a moment, she didn't know whether to be shocked by Third Miss Liang's vocabulary or by how hard she was working to support her wife.

However, because of her influence, the comments below slowly increased.

Accounts began praising Xu Qingzhu's looks.

Zhou Yi'an, who had been sitting quietly in the corner, suddenly spoke up faintly: "Is that Liang Shi?"

Sally & Cherry: "..."

Sally said righteously: "Zhou Yi'an, if I were you, I would consciously withdraw from this war, because I know it's impossible to win. No matter how excellent you are, in Liang Shi's eyes, her most beloved is still Blanche."

"It doesn't matter." Zhou Yi'an put away her phone, her tone casual and languid, "As long as it's a fruit I like, whether it tastes good or not, as long as I can pluck it, I'm happy."

Sally: "..."

She turned to ask Cherry: "What does she mean?"

Lin Luoxi was speechless for a moment, then impatiently explained in English: "She will use any means necessary to insert herself into Blanche and Liang Shi's marriage."

Sally was indignant: "...This person! Stubborn and unrepentant!"

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Liang Shi didn't yet know that she had already embarrassed herself in front of so many people. After posting dozens of comments consecutively...

Xu Qingzhu began displaying pictures of the autumn new products.

After each picture was displayed, it would be accompanied by the actual item.

Although Xu Qingzhu had been there for only a short time, in such a short period, she had completed an entire set of designs, coordinated the work to produce the actual items, and held the launch event on schedule.

Her execution ability was admirable enough.

Liang Shi was watching with great interest when a staff member called: "A376, A377."

Liang Shi reluctantly closed her phone and walked toward the audition room, but encountered Chen Liuying at the door.

As well as—Bai Weiwei.

Sigh, truly enemies on a narrow road⁴.

Liang Shi sighed in her heart.

Footnotes: ¹ Yang Shuyan: A famous actress character in this story's entertainment industry, apparently very popular ² Haiwei: Another jewelry brand mentioned as a competitor to Minghui ³ Rainbow farts (彩虹屁): Chinese internet slang for excessive praise or compliments, especially those given by fans to their idols ⁴ Enemies on a narrow road (冤家路窄): A Chinese idiom meaning that enemies or rivals are bound to meet in awkward situations